India, but they run into a different predicament: administrations often won't allow festivals on dates prescribed by Puri. In Lucknow this year, for instance, ISKCON reportedly sought permission to hold the return rath yatra on the prescribed date, but "the authorities expressed difficulty in granting permission" since it wasn't a public holiday or a Sunday. "If permissions become so challenging even in India, the very land of Lord Jagannath, one can imagine the far greater difficulties devotees face in foreign countries," he says.

Takeaways

- **Shree Jagannatha Temple Administration upbraids ISKCON for holding rath yatra events on "random days"**
- **ISKCON says bhakti is more important than blind ritual, cites logistical issues in getting dates in Indian, world cities**

According to ISKCON, its adjustments are meant to spread the joy within whatever window is available. In New York, since 1976, ISKCON has been holding the rath yatra on July 18. In Australia, it's shifted to December to dodge the misfortune of dragging chariots through biting July winters. Convenience, not canon, becomes the rule. ISKCON insists this is not sacrilege but strategy—the only way to keep Jagannath's chariot rolling across continents. Inter alia, this is a clash of two worldviews: Puri sees authenticity only in fidelity to ritual; ISKCON invokes the bhakti spirit that transcends rigidities. "Do we listen to Chaitanya Mahaprabhu or SJTA?" Das asked pointedly. There's another temporal shadow that falls over the whole episode: the recent rift between Odisha and Bengal over the inauguration of the Jagannath Dham in Digha. ■

GUJARAT

Garba Goes Uber Luxe

Gujarat's Navratri is a buzzing Rs 15,000 crore industry now—a whirligig of festive consumerism

By **Jumana Shah**



AP

SOARING CRESCENDO People perform Garba on the first night of Navratri in Ahmedabad, Sept. 22

NEVER HAS A spiritual prayer dance elicited such zest, pomp and excitement—among the faithful or otherwise—as the garba does in these parts. The one foolproof meter of the Gujarati soul is where they put their money. And here, the coins rain down in sync with the dance beats. Over the past three years, Navratri has been a soaring crescendo in Gujarat. An industry of joy that, by 2025, is getting valued above Rs 15,000 crore. That's up by an amazing 33 per cent over 2024, the highest balletic leap yet.

During Navratri, the nine nights of holy festivity, the dancing circles of the garba would light up the chowk of a village or mohalla, equivalent spaces in urban